Shields and Shortcomings

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Teen And Up Audiences

Archive Warning:
No Archive Warnings Apply

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F/F

Fandom:
She-Ra and the Princesses of Power (2018)

Relationship:
Adora/Catra (She-Ra), Adora & Mara (She-Ra), Catra & Scorpia (She-Ra), Catra & Double Trouble (She-Ra), Bow & Catra (She-Ra), Adora & Glimmer (She-Ra)

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Additional Tags:
Grayskull Squadron - Freeform, Alternate Universe - Modern Setting, Alternate Universe - Superheroes/Superpowers, Alternate Universe - Modern with Magic, Rescue Missions, Rescue, Kidnapping, Tags Contain Spoilers, Mind Control, Communication, Identity Reveal, Adora Needs Therapy (She-Ra), Adora is in Love with Catra (She-Ra), Catra is in Love with Adora (She-Ra), Comfort, Love Confessions, POV Catra (She-Ra)

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by ResFlower

Summary

"Did you have enough sense to come alone, sister?" Catra rolls her eyes, knowing Mara isn't looking at her. She hates this trite supervillain monologuing. Adora's face twitches into a smile for a moment.

"Yes. I'm not looking for any trouble. Just give me Catra back."

"Well, if you want her back-" Mara jostled her forward, roughly grabbing her arms and twisting them painfully "-you are going to have to give me your sword Adora." Adora's eyes are blazing blue as she lets out a low growl.

"Don't touch her. Don't even look at her, Mara."

OR

There is a rescue mission and Catra and Adora have a long-overdue conversation. Superhero AU.

Notes

Thanks again to BlueCoin00 for beta reading! She is back on her ADHD meds and absolutely ravaged this chapter as a result! Yay health!

This is being posted slightly ahead of schedule almost entirely due to her monumental efforts.

I hope you all enjoy it!

See the end of the work for more notes

Catra did not think she would be on the cusp of a panic attack in the restroom of one of Bright Moon's trendiest restaurants, but clearly the unexpected was on the menu tonight. Her hands are shaking, and her chest is way too tight like an imaginary corset is trying to squeeze her organs out of place.

She shuts her eyes, tries to slow her breathing and her mind. It doesn't work.

When she heard the word She-ra come out of Adora's mouth she froze, thinking that somehow Adora found her biggest secret. That the word Wildcat wouldn't fall far behind She-ra.

But then she saw Adora's eyes flash a glowing blue, a blue she had seen so many times during training, meetings, fighting side by side. So much fell into place.

She worked so hard to keep her two lives separate. Now, they have collided in a way she doesn't think she can recover from. There is no hiding from Adora anymore, for better or for worse.

She hears a knock on the bathroom door.

"Occupied," she yells out, hoping against hope that Adora isn't on the other side of the door.

The knocks become a loud thud. Catra tugs on her hair.

"I said it's fucking occupied-" she feels rather than hears the explosion that rips the door off its hinges and sends her sprawling on the floor.

Her ears are ringing. It affects her balance as she tries to stand. It takes a moment for her vision to come into focus. When it does, she sees a few masked men in Grayskull colors running into the bathroom. What the hell are they doing in a random restaurant? Are they here for her? For Adora? Her stomach clenches in fear.

The tallest one smirks almost leisurely walking up to her.

"Come quietly and this doesnt need to be bad for you girl." Catra doesnt bother responding.

She catches him by surprise and kicks him straight in the gut. Her shirt rips as she rolls her arm back to deliver a punch to another. She mentally curses, she really likes this suit.

She knocks two of them out, but there are two more Grayskull henchmen coming into the bathroom and not a lot of space to maneuver. She backs away to a corner, pulls the hand dryer off the wall, and beams it at another goon's head.

She tries to reach into her suit pocket where she stashed her tech claws, but she feels someone bang her head into the bathroom mirror. She hears glass break and then loses consciousness.

Catra feels cold wetness along her body. She starts moving and her body protests the movement making her ache. She opens her eyes and finds herself alone in what she assumes is a holding cell. There are bars enclosing her on one side, stone walls on the other three. Across from her, there is another cell but it's empty.

She is still wearing her suit, crumpled and bloodied. Her head is throbbing, and her arms are bound in front of her. She moves both arms up and touches her head. Some flakes of dried blood are on her hand. Well, that cant be good.

Catra starts searching for any means of escape. She stands and walks towards the door trying to open it. It is predictably locked. She tests the strength of the bars, thinks about potentially melting them. It would be a messy project and time-consuming, not really her first choice.

She studies the walls as well, looking for any latches but no such luck. She then looks out towards the other cells and finds that they

are all empty. She seems to be the only prisoner, so no one to ally herself with. She summarizes that the best course of action is to wait and knock out a guard to get out.

After getting her bearings, she slumps onto a cot in the corner of her cell. She thinks of Adora's hurt face when she walked away from that table at the restaurant. She just needed a moment to process and now who knows what Adora thinks. She stares unseeingly at the bars that keep her in her cell.

Catra puts her head in her hands. She feels so stupid. It all makes sense- too much sense. Every time that Adora was busy because of work. Every time that She-ra was unavailable when Catra had plans with Adora.

Now that she really thinks of it, of course Adora is She-ra. She is so kind and good, unfailingly ready to save the day no matter what. That goodness just seeps out of her in a way that demands attention.

Her stomach clenches as she thinks of all the lies that Adora told her, the same lies Catra has justified for years when she tells them. On the other side of them, she can admit they sting. She recognizes how hypocritical that is, but she can't help that it hurts.

Catra puts her head between her knees and takes a few deep breaths, trying to switch her focus.

She knows the Alliance will come for her. She knows Adora, and even if she didn't have superpowers, she would move mountains for Catra. She just isn't sure if she wants to wait or try to take these bastards down on her own.

She starts to stand again but quickly sits back down when she hears footsteps.

"Hello. Catra is it?" Catra looks up at the woman standing outside of her cell.

She recognizes Mara from the few times the Alliance has gone against the Grayskull Squadron, although usually, Light Hope was the face of the operation. Catra wonders why she hasn't seen her.

Catra keeps quiet, staring impassively at Mara while she tries to keep her hands from shaking. Mara opens the cell and quickly steps inside, locking the door behind her. She continues, unbothered by Catra's silence.

"I can see why Adora likes you. You knocked out three of my cadets before one of them could get a handle on you. Where did Adora meet you, an MMA fighting gym?"

A chill ran down Catra's spine at the casual way Mara said Adora's name. Did the reason the Grayskull Squadron kidnapped Catra have to do with Adora? What would Mara of all people know about Adora's preferences?

Mara's comment also makes Catra suspect that she doesn't know that Catra is Wildcat. She remains silent, looking down at the ground.

Mara comes close and grabs Catra's chin tightly in her hand, tilting her head to look into Mara's eyes. The power in Mara's grip is a warning, but Catra doesn't care. Catra grits her teeth and averts her gaze, refusing to give Mara the satisfaction.

"You are quite rude you know. Not a great impression to make on Adora's family." That makes Catra's eyes snap up. Mara gives her a smile, cracks on the sword on her waist glow red.

That isn't possible. Adora doesn't have a family. Same as Catra.

"Oh, Adora never told you? I'm her sister. She was destined to be the hero of Grayskull, to fight for its honor. Instead, she ran like a coward, crawling to the Alliance."

Oh. Adora has a literal evil villain family. Same as Catra. Mara shoots Catra a look of fake concern.

"Did she even bother to tell you she is She-ra?" That one stings. Catra finally spits out at Mara.

"Just stop. What do you even want with Adora?" Mara finally loosens her grip on Catra's face, lazily taking a few steps towards the cell bars.

"Not sure if your honey told you this, but she is a thief. She stole something very important from us." Mara's face curls into a sneer and the sword glows a brighter red.

"More than that, she betrayed Grayskull's mission. Using the sword of protection on behalf of the Alliance," she reaches one finger out to touch each bar as she passes them, almost like she is inspecting them.

"So we stole something of hers. A sword for a girlfriend feels like a fair trade, right?" Mara walks towards the cell door again, locking Catra in alone once more. Mara's eyes flicker red. That's weird.

"The real question is what she values more. For both our sakes, I hope it's you," Mara stops before she is out of sight and turns back to Catra.

"Some friendly advice, dear ," Mara's tone is anything but friendly . She whispers as if conspiring with Catra, but her voice drips condescension.

"She was raised to be a weapon, Catra. You'd best recall that before you make a home with a monster."

Catra spits towards Mara's feet. She doesn't manage to hit but the message is clear. Mara makes a disgusted noise in the back of her throat and finally leaves Catra's line of sight. Good riddance.

Catra can feel her heart race as she thinks about all these things about Adora she shouldn't know. Adora was raised in the Grayskull Squadron, a verifiable First Ones cult. Adora has a sister who is unhinged enough to kidnap Adora's girlfriend.

There is so much about Adora she doesn't know. There is so much Adora doesn't know about Catra either. From the moment Adora said she was She-ra, Catra realized she would probably have to tell Adora that she was Wildcat. But now? She doesn't want any secrets between them.

Catra shakes her head and forces herself to stand up. She has to focus on how to get out of here, back to Adora so they can sort this mess out.

Her tech claws might still be in her suit pocket if she can just reach it. It feels awkward but she manages to slip her hand into her pocket and reaches for the bracelets.

Wow, the Grayskull Squadron is full of idiots that didn't give her a basic pat-down while she was unconscious. It also confirms her suspicion that they do not suspect that she is Wildcat.

She manages to hook one tech claw onto her wrist but she can't get the other one without cutting her bindings. She slips it back into her front pocket to make it more accessible.

Catra looks around her drab prison cell. She could try to touch the lock, but given that she has no idea where she is, or what the Grayskull Squadron is capable of, she resolves to wait and use the element of surprise to her advantage.

The next time Catra sees Mara, she drags her out of the cell, brusquely walking and pulling on the bindings holding Catra's hand.

"Your girlfriend is here for you. If you sit still and stay quiet, you'll probably live." Catra keeps her eyes downcast, modeling obedience.

Her heart races as she thinks of seeing Adora again. As they walk, she tries to take in any details- like exit signs, or an irregular hallway- that might clue her into an escape path.

Most of the halls she passes look the same, all boring gray tones. They pass through a few common areas with small kitchenettes and dining hall furniture. The Grayskull emblem is printed on seemingly random things from coffee mugs to doorknobs.

They pass a few other people, but they pay Catra no mind. They all give Mara a wide berth, not looking her in the face directly. Some glance nervously from the corner of their eyes and pick up their pace. Really, it seems like most of these people are afraid of Mara.

She notices at least two passageways that look like they might lead outside the compound. That'll have to do for now.

They finally go into what looks like an emptied-out laboratory. There are random barrels around the edges of the room as well as boxes with beakers, graduated cylinders, and other glassware. A few tables with fume hoods were at the edge of the room.

Inside, there are multiple Grayskull guards standing around and a lone figure in the middle. Adora is in her She-ra suit, but she has her mask removed and no other Alliance members in sight.

Adora looks at her with a mix of desperation and relief, her eyes running up and down her frame checking for injuries. Catra sends her what she hopes is a reassuring smile. Catra hopes the idiot wasn't stupid enough to show up alone.

"Did you have enough sense to come alone, sister?" Catra rolls her eyes, knowing Mara isn't looking at her. She hates this trite supervillain monologuing. Adora's face twitches into a smile for a moment.

"Yes. I'm not looking for any trouble. Just give me Catra back."

"Well, if you want her back-" Mara jostled her forward, roughly grabbing her arms and twisting them painfully "-you are going to have to give me your sword Adora." Adora's eyes are blazing blue as she lets out a low growl.

"Don't touch her. Don't even look at her, Mara." Mara smirks, a cocky asshole if there ever was one.

"How about this?" Adora puffs up her chest, standing to her full height. She swaggers forward, holding the sword tightly in her hands.

"Fight me for the sword, Mara. You'll have the sword and I'll be dead if you win."

She sees both Adora and Mara look at her and she realizes she let out a choked sound when Adora casually mentioned dying. Mara glances back at Adora, her own eyes glowing blue.

"How can I say no to that Adora? You really know how to make your sister's day."

With no warning, Mara shoves Catra aside, unsheathes her sword, and starts swinging at Adora. Adora strikes back the clanging of the two First Ones' swords ringing loud in the large room.

Another guard grabs Catra by her tied arms. Catra looks around trying to figure out the best moment to escape when she catches a flash of purple in one of the air vents. Catra lets out a small, relieved exhale, knowing that has to be Entrapta.

"I don't understand, Mara!" Adora yells as she moves around Mara. Their swords have not stopped swinging.

"Why do you hate me so much? You wanted to leave the Grayskull Squadron with me! And then you ratted me out to Light Hope!" The sword at Mara's side starts to glow a deep red as Mara grips it tighter.

"You were destined to be the hero of Grayskull, Adora, to fight for its honor. Instead, you ran like a coward, crawling to the Alliance!" Mara's eyes start glowing the red of the sword.

Adora says something but Catra doesnt pay attention, still stuck on Mara's words. The words make Catra turn her head, really staring at Mara. She was pretty sure those were the exact words that Mara told her earlier in her cell. Verbatim. That's not normal.

It wasnt the only thing out of place. Mara's eyes look like something out of a horror movie, blood-red and crazed. The sword also glows red and looks like it is cracking around the edges. Catra had spent enough time in her life around Hordak's tech to know what mind control looks like.

The fight between Mara and Adora is a brutal slog and Catra fears there is no end in sight. She also hasnt seen a hint of the Alliance since she saw Entrapta.

She quietly activates her tech claw and cuts the bindings that are restraining her arm. The guard fails to notice, watching the fight between Mara and Adora avidly.

Her hand quietly creeps into her front pocket, and she secures both tech claws. She wishes she had her whip, but these would have to do.

As she prepares to strike the guard, she sees Adora slip and fall backward. Mara runs forward, ready to drive her sword straight through Adora.

"Adora!" Catra yells. Catra reaches for her power, bringing flames up to the surface of her arms to burn her captor. The guard quickly releases her in surprise. She surges forward, getting between Mara and Adora. She jumps up and lands on Mara's shoulders, pushing hard so she loses her balance and goes sprawling on the ground.

Mara looks up at Catra, eyes turning brown and widening as she sees the flames around Catra. Her eyes flicker red again and she smirks.

"Oh, that's precious. Little Adora is dating her favorite superhero. Wildcat, isn't it?" Catra could care less about Mara right now. Her eyes fall to Adora.

Adora's gaze is searing. She looks a mix of awed and confused. Before Catra can react, Mara yells.

"Squadron! Attack!" All hell breaks loose. Catra grabs Adora's hand and pulls her to her feet. The soldiers are charging them from every side, a sea of gray and white. Catra and Adora turn back-to-back and then they are fighting together like always.

"Left!" Adora barks out, Catra dodges out of the way and slashes the cadet who tried to catch her by surprise. They successfully fight a few soldiers but as soon as they knock down some, a few others get back up. Even more are coming in from the main compound. Catra hears a smash and through the main door, she sees Scorpia and a few others come in.

The fight evens out some after that. Arrow has his weapon of choice trained to the main door so anyone entering the room would have to brave the possibility of an arrow to the face to aid their commander.

Double Trouble turns into different cadets or even Mara, catching them by surprise when she attacks. Scorpia, Shimmer, and Frosta perform an all-out offensive, fighting whoever is in front of them.

Catra doesn't stray far from Adora, watching her back and making sure Mara stays away from her. She knows if Adora seriously hurts her sister, even in self-defense, she would never forgive herself.

There is a lull in the fight that Catra takes advantage of to talk to Adora. Catra grabs Adora's hand to get her attention. Adora looks shocked at her touch.

"Adora, I think something weird is happening with Mara's sword. You need to break it." Adora sputters.

"It's an ancient relic Cat, I can't just smash it." Catra could cry from how familiar Adora's exasperated tone is.

"Yes, you can. I think it's messing with her mind or something. You can't tell me she always had the unhinged blood eye look going on." Adora's eyes flash with pain at the reminder.

"Okay, we want to break the Sword of Power. What's the plan?" Catra can see Mara fighting Frosta, sword waved high. Catra takes off running straight at Adora.

"Boost me Dor!" Likely through sheer muscle memory alone, Adora squares up and bends forward slightly, standing at the perfect height for Catra to land on her shoulders.

Catra jumps up and Adora uses her strength to launch her forward. Catra flips through the air and snags Mara's sword mid-strike. Holy shit she wasn't sure that was going to work.

Mara's head snaps up and when she sees Catra with her sword she snarls and runs after her. Catra runs but she looks over her shoulder and sees an unhinged Mara quickly catching up to her. Catra welcomes the heat as she brings her flames down her arms, lighting them up like matches. Mara flinches away from the sudden brightness, putting a hand over her eyes and taking a step back from the rolling heat. Taking advantage of the momentary distraction, Catra heaves the sword with all her might towards Adora.

Adora catches it easily, almost like her hand is a magnet that attracts Mara's sword. Catra turns and activates her tech claws continuing to fight Mara in earnest. She needs to keep her from Adora.

"Do it!" Catra yells over her shoulder. Adora bears all her strength down on the sword. The sword emits a bomb of light, shattering as if made of glass.

Mara drops her fighting stance suddenly, movements woozy as if drunk. She then collapses forward, dropping into Catra's arms. Catra gently puts Mara down and looks at her slack face. All the fighting stops. The Grayskull cadets look at each other and turn to stampede through the main door now that their commander is down.

Adora rushes to her side, panic clear on her face. She grabs Catra's hand squeezing it tight. Mara groans her eyes open briefly. She focuses on Adora.

"Kid? What-what am I doing?" Adora's eyes widen and water at the nickname.

"Mara?" Adora whispers fearfully.

"Yeah, it's me. Did I really- did we just fight like that?" Adora crushes Mara in a hug, sobbing.

"We did Mar. We've been fighting for a while now." Adora sniffles.

"Let's not fight anymore, yeah?" Mara says as if it's that easy. Her eyes shine with love as she gingerly puts her arm around Adora. Adora nods into Mara's shoulder, continuing to cry.

Catra gives Adora's shoulder a squeeze and takes a step back, letting Adora be with her sister. Adora sends her a grateful look as she helps Mara to her feet. They will have time to talk later. She has Grayskull cadets to round up now.

Adora manages to get a disoriented Mara onto the transport after many more tears were shared amongst the sisters. Catra gives them a wide berth. The transport is long and sterile with lots of drawers for supplies and benches to sit on.

Catra notices Scorpia scanning the transport as soon as she gets on. Her eyes stop on Catra, and she wheel barrels towards her.

Scorpia crushes Catra in an embrace, lifting her at least a foot in the half off the air.

"Oh Wildcat! Im so happy you are ok!" Catra pats Scorpia's back in response.

"Thanks, big gal." Scorpia suddenly shoves Catra at arm' s length and

"I mean are you ok? Now that the Alliance knows?" Scorpia gestures up to Catra's unmasked face. Catra takes a deep breath.

"I- honestly havent had a chance to think about it." She was - continues to be- so worried about Adora's reaction that she hadnt the space to consider what it means that the Alliance at large knows her identity.

She looks around the transport and sees more than allies. She sees her friends. People she trusts with her life and spends most of her time with. She feels a rush of relief and lets down her guard with them.

"I definitely wish I could have made the decision to tell them on my own terms, not in an emergency." Her heart squeezes itself in her chest as she thinks of Adora's face when she saw Catra standing over Mara using Wildcat's powers.

"I think itll be okay . Im not sure that I want the public to know , but I trust the Alliance. I know everyone has my back." Catra knows that she will never get rid of the shadows she feels in her mind, but maybe having fewer secrets from the people she trusts would make them quieter.

Scorpia studies Catra's face carefully as a weird, excited expression comes over her face. She lowers her head to whisper in Catra's ear.

"So. Y our Adora is She-ra?" Catra blushes. She isnt surprised Scorpia put two and two together.

"Yeah. I just found out right before I got kidnapped. Again." Her eyes stray to Adora sitting in her She-ra get up. It still felt surreal. Scorpia gives Catra's shoulder a squeeze.

"You'll figure it out, Wildcat." It is on the tip of her tongue to scold Scorpia for calling her Wildcat while around others, but then her frame relaxes, remembering that it isn't a secret any longer, at least here.

Arrow catches Catra's eye and walks up to her.

"The name is Catra." She supplies at his quirked eyebrow. He rolls his eyes playfully.

"Catra, still Arrow I'm afraid. You want me to get you something else to wear?" Catra looks down at her suit in tatters. The sleeves of both the dress shirt and the suit jacket were burned right off, making them look like a vest. She shakes her head at him.

"Eh, this is definitely a fashion statement. I'll be home soon anyway, and I can get a shower before I change." Catra shrugs. Arrow nods.

"What about your head?" Arrow gestures at the dried blood trailing down Catra's forehead.

"That, I would appreciate help with." Arrow sits and pulls one of the transport first aid kits from underneath the bench he sat on. He pats the spot next to him, eyeing Catra expectantly.

As soon as he sits, he starts cleaning the dried blood off the wound. Catra winces.

"How did you get this? Pretty nasty. Doesn't look like it needs stitches though." Catra stays still as he finishes cleaning and is now putting down gauze.

"Got sent headfirst into a mirror at the restaurant I was taken from. Can't say I remember much after that." Catra tries to go for

unaffected but she isn't sure she pulls it off.

"Ouch." Arrow winces in sympathy.

He catches Catra covertly looking at Adora talking to Mara and Shimmer, Entrapta standing closely behind. It's weird, seeing Mara chatting away as if she hadn't kidnapped Catra and tried to kill Adora a few hours earlier.

"Entrapta thinks the sword was infected by some of Prime's tech. She collected all the pieces so she could study it in the lab. Mara is pretty out of it. She doesn't remember much of what has happened since her sword got infected." He supplies helpfully.

"How long has that been?" She thinks of not having a say in her body's decisions, of potentially being a small voice in your own mind, unable to stop yourself from doing terrible things. She shudders. Catra can't imagine not having control of her own faculties.

"Since Adora defected it seems." Catra sucks in a sharp breath. She isn't sure when Adora left the Grayskull Squadron, but it has to have been before Catra met Adora.

"That's a long time."

"Yeah. Entrapta is pretty sure she's going to recover at least some of her memories with time." Arrow pats her hand, indicating that he finished cleaning up her head. Catra smiles gratefully, bumping his shoulder.

"That's good at least." Silver linings and all that. Thinking about Mara and the Grayskull Squadron reminds Catra of something else she thought about while in her cell.

"Do they know where Light Hope is?" A dark shadow passes over Arrow's face.

"No, no one knows where she is. We are hoping that if Mara can remember something she might know her location." Catra suppresses a groan.

Catra makes to stand up from her seat, about to demand to be let out of the transport so she could interrogate a few Grayskull guards about Light Hope, Double Trouble strolls over, shit-eating grin in place. Catra actually groans this time.

"So, kitten, what's it like knocking boots with blondie over there? Don't spare any details." Catra generally liked Double Trouble but at times like these they pissed Catra off.

"Wouldn't you like to know, DT?" Catra rebuffs their question.

"That's why I ask, darling. I figured you two were up to something, but this is even better than what even I had imagined."

"How about you keep your imaginings off of me and my girlfriend." Catra raises her voice a bit.

Adora seems to notice because she catches Catra's eyes from across the transport. She looks beautiful even though her eyes are red-rimmed from crying and her hair is a mess from tugging on it. Adora tentatively waves, a small smile on her lips.

"Duty calls kitten." DT had a knowing grin.

"Fuck off." Catra gripes as she stands up from the bench. DT stops her with her hand.

"I am glad She-Ra's sister didn't hurt you too seriously." Her voice is soft. Double Trouble then bumps Catra as she walks past. She knows it's their way of saying they're glad Catra isn't dead. She rolls her eyes.

Catra walks right up to Adora, unable to stay away for much longer. Adora meets her halfway. Catra can feel her heart beating through

her chest.

"So. Im Wildcat."Catra felt naked saying the words aloud even though she had all but said it in action.

"I figured. From, you know , the acrobatic display. And the tech claws. Also, Shimmer told me on the way here."Catra shoots Shimmer a glare.

Shimmer throws up her arms in exasperation. One of Shimmer's eyes is twitching, and her arms have a slight tremble to them.

"Okay!Neither of you gets to be mad at me when you are the most useless lesbians on this side of the Etherian Meridian. I have been keeping this quiet for over five years!"

"You knew we were friends the whole time?"That actually makes sense, but Catra hadnt realized the extent of the knowledge Shimmer possessed.

"Yeah. Duh."Shimmer deadpans. Catra is exposed under her judgey stare.

"Look. At some point, Im going to roast both of you with every instance it should have been patently obvious to you both that you knew each other in your civilian life."Shimmer pauses.

"Preferably with a cocktail in hand."Shimmer waves her hand as if a cocktail will magically appear in it.

"For now , can you two stop being idiots and just be together?"Catra stares at Adora then. She grabs Adora's hand and entwines their fingers.

"I really hope so Sparkles."Although the words are directed at Shimmer, her eyes are on Adora.

"Mara is going to stay in an Alliance safe house tonight. She doesnt really feel safe and Light Hope might come looking for her , so she

needs to be secured. Do you want to come to my apartment?" Adora asks timidly.

"We have a lot to talk about, don't we?" Catra says rubbing her thumb over Adora's hand.

"Yeah, we really do." Adora squeezes her hand.

By the time they are finally back in Adora's apartment, everything is stilted between them again. When they were fighting, it felt natural to have each other's back and communicate.

Now, all their secrets were suspended in the air between them. There was just one secret Catra still kept.

Catra grabbed both of Adora's hands as soon as she finished locking her front door. Adora looks geared up for another fight. Catra gently cups her face, and she feels Adora relax under her touch.

"Adora, I love you." Catra flung it out for Adora to have. Adora's eyes widened, her arms coming around to hold Catra.

"You love me?" Catra presses her forehead against Adora's. She can't help the laugh that escapes her at Adora's wonder.

"You're such an idiot." Adora smiles like it's a compliment.

"I love you too." Adora breathes. Adora leans forward as if to kiss her but stops right before, eyes asking for permission. Catra closes the distance between them, and it feels like coming home. A few moments later Catra breaks off the kiss, a teasing smile on her lips.

"You know, this is technically the second time we tell each other." They stay huddled close together.

"Hm?" Adora makes a confused noise.

"In Hordak's creepy vault, we told each other we loved each other. Unless you are in love with some other best friend." Catra meant it as a joke, but Adora's voice is solemn as she answers.

"Never, Cat. It's always you for me." Adora's eyes glow as she stares at Catra, a soft look of adoration on her face. A fresh bruise is blooming on her shoulder, her hair is in complete disarray, there is a cut on her trembling bottom lip. She's a total mess and she is still so incredibly beautiful. They hold on to each other for a moment longer, ignoring the grit and grime that clung to them both.

"Look, I know you've been through a lot today with Mara. We have a lot to talk about, but it doesn't have to be right now if you don't have space for it." Catra leans back to look at Adora's face.

"I just wanted you to know that I love you and I'm not going anywhere with you." Adora stares at her softly. Her lips are pressed together as if she is holding back a laugh.

"I was about to say that *I* know *you've* been through a lot today. You know, being kidnapped? Ring any bells?" Catra rolls her eyes.

"Eh. It's old hat at this point. Honestly, I'm a little offended I've gotten kidnapped this frequently, clearly, the villains aren't taking me seriously. Is it the height, do you think?" Adora snorts.

"Yeah, you are pretty shrimpy Cat." Adora lifts Catra up with one hand as if gauging the weight of fruit at the grocery store.

"Hey! I resent that!" Catra looks at Adora accusingly. Catra then squeezes Adora's arm.

"You've been holding out on me." She accuses.

"I mean yeah what explanation would I have for using super strength to carry my girlfriend?" Adora's eyes twinkle in amusement. Catra petulantly rolls her eyes.

"I mean you don't need an excuse now ." Catra raises a single eyebrow, eyes full of intent. Adora sputters.

"Okay , we should put a pin in that for now." Adora's cheeks are flushed red.

"So, you feel good? T o talk, I mean. At least a little bit?" Adora prompts. Catra's eyes soften.

"Y eah, Dor. Let's just shower and order some takeout. Then we can talk." Adora nods in acknowledgment.

Catra starts to walk towards Adora's bedroom in search of one of Adora's old college sweatshirts when Adora crushes Catra to her chest.

"Dor this isn't an appropriate use of your super strength." Catra manages to strangle out.

"Sorry , sorry, sorry," Adora chants.

"It's just. Y ou got kidnapped and I was so worried. I just needed a hug." Adora finishes lamely . Catra melts into her arms.

They eventually separate, shuffling around the apartment getting ready until they are both curled up in Adora's bed both clean and full. A heavy silence settles between them as they lay down facing each other. Adora breaks it.

"Maybe we can talk about what happened at the restaurant?" She suggests.

"Y eah, I guess we have to start somewhere." Catra narrows her eyes at Adora.

"First of f, I will say that picking a public venue to reveal your secret identity goes against all logic." Adora deflates.

"Yeah, in hindsight Im not sure how I thought that would work out well. Maybe it was self-sabotage?" Adora rubs the back of her neck and looks away.

"I just- I was taken aback by your reaction and I guess what Im wondering is... is it a deal-breaker for you? That Im She-ra?" Catra stares at Adora with wide eyes.

"No Adora, of course not. She-ra is a part of you, why would it bother me?" Adora visibly relaxes at Catras answer .

"You didnt think that it was too much?" Adora stares at Catra timidly as she gets out the question.

"That Im too much?" Adora whispers her rephrased question. Catra reaches out and cups Adora's cheek in her hand.

"Never , Dor . Every part of you is important to me, even the parts that you havent told me about because they make you who you are. It could never be too much." Catra wipes away a stray tear rolling down Adora's cheek. She keeps talking.

"I went to the bathroom because I needed a moment to collect myself. I promise you, I was going to come back. Probably tell you that I was Wildcat although I didnt get that far in thinking it through before I got kidnapped." She settles herself into Adoras side so she can stare at the ceiling as she talks. She feels her stomach clench as she mentally prepares herself to keep going.

"You have to understand Dor . This right here? Is my biggest fear . Telling you about Wildcat. When you told me you were She-ra it felt like everything was falling apart." Adora is quiet for a moment.

"I dont understand," Adora admits. "Why were you that afraid of telling me?"

"I need to tell you more about how I became Wildcat for you to get it I think." Catra has a knot in her throat. She decides to start with what

Adora does know.

"You know how I told you that my foster mother was a bitch and I hated her?" Adora nods.

"It's Shadow. She raised me since I was four." Catra glances at Adora and waits for the revulsion to set into Adora's eyes. Instead, Adora looks at Catra with sadness. Catra presses on, eyes back on the ceiling.

"She got me after my parents died in a fire. She told me that the Alliance set my house on fire because they had elemental magic, you know, like I have."

"I grew up hating the Alliance with all that I was. From the moment I met Shadow, she trained me to fight. Martial arts, gymnastics, fencing, anything that could give me a leg up. All of that on top of training my supernatural abilities." Catra doesnt have the heart to look at Adora but she can feel Adora rubbing her hand up and down her arm.

"Shadow wanted me to infiltrate the Alliance as a spy, but before she deemed' I was ready, the Director found me. She had been looking for me since my parents died." Catra took in a shuddering breath.

"Turns out, my parents were in the Alliance, and it was Shadow who murdered them. She lied to me the whole time." Her voice sounded bitter even to her own ears.

"I had worked so hard to please her. To earn her love. And she- she made me an orphan." Catra could feel the tears streaming down her face. She takes in a shuddering breath.

"The fucked-up thing is that a part of me still wants her to be proud. Or at least to think that I was worth something." She admits in a quiet whisper. Adora stays silent as she continues to move her hand rhythmically over Catra's arm.

"I did fucked up shit Adora. I was raised to be evil by the worst person I know. Im not good."The truth laid bare for Adora now .

"That' s why I never wanted you to know about Wildcat. I didnt think you would want me if you knew. I didnt think anyone would want me. Not as a friend and certainly not as a girlfriend."Catra is defeated, bracing for what Adora will think. Adora pulls her close again. She tilts Catra's face so that they are making eye contact. Adora bears a fiercely determined look in her eyes as she speaks.

"Catra, how old were you when the Director found you and you joined the Alliance?"Adora's tone is calm but leading, her eyes steady.

"Seventeen."Catra answers, unsure where Adora was going with this. Adora's bottom lip starts to tremble and Catra feels her arms tighten around her.

"Y ou were a child. You were abused. And even with everything you went through, you left everything you knew behind because you wanted to do good. You are good."Her voice shakes as she recites each part like they are all facts.

"If anything, Catra, Im more in awe of you than I have ever been." Catra stares at her agape.

Its the same feeling as when Adora said that Catra inspired her to join the Alliance. This big bubbling thing that feels like itll burst out of Catra's chest. But more, because now she knows it's Adora.

Adora trails her finger up and down Catra's arm, lighter pressure than before, almost shy.

"I was so worried I was going to lose you today . I was near hysterics in the transport on the way there."Adora admits in a quiet whisper .

"Shimmer told me you were Wildcat to reassure me that you could take care of yourself until we found you. It didnt really sink in until I

saw you."Catra catches Adora' s eyes again, shocked.

"At the time, I thought you didn't know because of the way you looked at me. When I started fighting Mara. You looked so shocked you know? I felt terrible."Adora gives her a warm smile.

"I mean knowing it and seeing it is dif ferent you know? W atching you do the things I've seen Wildcat do thousands of times was jarring to say the least."Adora' s voice fills with quiet awe.

"And it's like how much time have we spent together and just never known you know? It's kind of a mind fuck."Adora flails her hands about.

"Y ou mean like Monday Alliance gym night or our multiple near-death experiences."Catra snarks. Realization blooms on Adora's face and she boops Catra's nose with an accusing finger.

"W ait! Y ou missed our vacation flight too! Y ou let me take the fall for that!"Catra smirks.

"Y eah, I felt a little bad about it but I felt justified at the time, you know, since I was kidnapped."Catra thinks about it for a moment.

"Y ou know, I'm pretty sure you've taken the fall a bunch of times." Adora is indignant.

"This might be the most upsetting thing about learning that you are Wildcat."Adora groused, crossing her arms. She is pouting.

Catra can't resist and leans up to kiss Adora. Adora melts and pulls Catra into her arms.

Adora's eyes are glowing so bright it's like there is a night light in the room. And it makes sense. Adora is this brilliant light that casts out the shadows in Catra's life.

"My golden girl,"Catra sighs.

At that, Adora's hair starts floating as it did at the Alliance meeting. Catra places one of the strands between her fingers, feels it subtly shift under her touch.

"Why does it do that?" Adora shrugs.

"I'm not exactly sure. It's definitely connected to-" Adora coughs and flushes a bit, "-emotions. It only really happens when I think about you." Adora admits shyly .

"Mara and I, our parents passed when we were pretty young. We didn't get many explanations for how our powers work. We might learn more now that Mara is on our side." A cloud of guilt passes over Adora's face.

"Do you want to talk about Mara?" Catra prompts. Adora considers it before shaking her head.

"Not today . I just can't believe I didn't realize she was being controlled. I really thought she was one of the bad guys. I feel like I let her down."

"I don't think I said thank you for that, by the way . I'm getting my sister back because of you." Adora gives Catra a grateful look that warms her.

"You don't need to thank me Dor . I'm really glad that you get to have your family back." Adora kisses the tip of Catra's nose.

"You're my family too, Cat. Even before we were dating." Catra's heart swells at that. Catra nuzzles into Adora's arm, feeling truly safe for the first time since the restaurant.

"Move in with me," Adora whispers. Catra's eyes snap to Adora's. Adora looks surprised the words came out of her mouth.

"We have been dating for less than six months, Adora." Adora suddenly looks determined and doubles down.

"I've been in love with you since I saw you in that chemistry class junior year . I think we've waited long enough."Adora's face turns shy. She looks at Catra from the corner of her eye.

"And honestly , the only reason I hadn't asked before is that I didn't know how to explain my secret superhero closet."Catra let out a squeaky laugh.

"How about we talk about moving in together in a few days after we process some of this more?"Adora deflates a bit at that.

"Yeah, you're right."Adora grumps.

"We have all the time in the world to figure it all out, Dor."That makes Adora smile.

"I know we have more things we have to talk about, but I'm beat."

"So, we are staying together? And we love each other?"Adora gives her a cheeky grin.

"Yeah Dor as long as it's what you want too."Catra peeks up at Adora.

Catra relaxes into Adora's arms, no secrets or guilt laying heavy between them. She didn't notice the weight before but now that it isn't there, everything feels different.

"Okay good. We can deal with everything else together."Adora tightens her arms around Catra.

Together. Catra loves the sound of that.

End Notes

I cant believe the main arc is completed! This would not have been written if it werent for the lovely people who left comments and kudos encouraging me to expand the universe. Im not really done with this universe yet for people who are wondering! Here are a few ideas I am thinking of writing:

-Maras adjustment after leaving the Grayskull Squadron
-Catras origin story
-Adoras origin story
-Their first date
-Government tries to repeal superhero immunity laws
-5 dates that get interrupted + 1 that doesnt
-Glimmer absolutely roasting Catra and Adora for how oblivious they have been

Let me know which of these ideas youd want to see, or other things- both in this universe or outside of it!

Im not going to be updating this universe every week because I will be posting other Catradora content.

Next Week: we have a fluffy valentines day coffee shop AU!

Im super thankful to all of you and if you enjoyed this, I would appreciate comments/kudos. Till next time!

Please drop by the archive and comment to let the author know if you enjoyed their work!